



Men on a mission: Besides Neeraj, India's other leading medal hopes include (L-R) Murali Sreeshankar in long jump (season's best: 8.38m), Gulveer Singh in 5000m (NR: 13:03.93), Praveen Chithravel in triple jump (season's best: 17.08m) and Tejas Shirse in 110m hurdles (season's best: 13.27s). **Below:** Although not a medal contender, Gurindervir Singh, who holds the national record of 10.09s in the 100m, will be aiming to edge closer to his career goal of breaking the 10-second barrier.

R. RAGU, BISWARANJAN ROUT & RITU RAJ KONWAR

BACK WHERE IT ALL BEGAN

Eight years after his Commonwealth Games breakthrough, Neeraj Chopra returns to lead a **promising** athletics contingent for India.

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Although he was already a Junior World and Asian champion by that point, there's a fair argument to be made that it was at the Gold Coast Commonwealth Games in April 2018 that a then 21-year-old Neeraj Chopra truly broke into the national reckoning by winning gold in the men's javelin throw.

That wouldn't, of course, be his last triumph at a multi-sport Games — he'd follow it up with gold at the 2018 Asian Games, a historic Olympic title at Tokyo 2021 and a silver at the Paris Games in 2024.

Gold Coast, though, would remain the last time Neeraj competed at the Commonwealth Games. He missed the 2022 edition in Birmingham after

suffering an injury at the World Championships a few weeks before the event.

In 2018, he was still in the early stages of his climb towards the pinnacle of world sport. He made it to the top, but it's taken enormous effort to stay there. Now, eight years later, Neeraj is back in CWG, ready to step into Scotstoun Stadium in Glasgow on July 30 as the undisputed poster boy of Indian athletics.

The last couple of seasons have been difficult for Neeraj. Now 28 years old, injuries have started to catch up with him. He failed to medal at last year's World Championships and then underwent a lengthy nine-month rehabilitation programme before beginning his 2026 season only last month.

On his return, he finished fourth at the Diamond League in Doha

